Foods and Trumpets in the Desert: A Reflection on the Homilies of Origen on Joshua

In his homilies on Joshua, Origen offers an extensive exegesis of the name Joshua, the crossing of the Jordan River, and the Israelites' conquest of Jericho. Further, in anticipation of this journey, Origen interprets the three foods required of the Israelites on their journey up to and through the Jordan River, equating them with spiritual foods. Throughout this series of homilies, Origen adopts a literal reading of Jesus into Joshua, as the reader finds in the footnotes to the Preface of Rufinus. This perspective is presented directly by Origen in *Homily 1*, where readers encounter Origen's introduction of Joshua as the first instance of the name "Jesus" in the Bible, signifying the importance of Joshua, rendered in Hebrew as Jesus, as "the name above every name" and reserved until the book of Exodus, exempting the ancient patriarchs in Genesis: Abraham, Isaac, Jacob, and even Moses. Because Origen's allegories occasionally render textual ambiguities between Joshua and Jesus, Jericho and the World, the Jordan River and Baptism, the Israelites and humanity, etc., this paper will also treat them interchangeably except where otherwise noted. This paper will focus on two aspects of Origen's Christological hermeneutic and intertextual exegesis: first, it will reflect on the three foods of the Israelites that sustained them on their journey through the wilderness into the Holy Land, then extend the allegory further into a Eucharistic reading. This paper will then conclude by addressing Origen's rendering of Jericho as the world into which Joshua/Jesus enters, initially through the Jordan River vis-à-vis baptism, then through His second coming, introducing further intertextual reference for the role of the trumpets.

In discussing the foods required by the Israelites on their exodus out of Egypt and to the Holy Land, Origen writes in *Homily 6*, "In this manner, three kinds of food in general are

described. The first one we certainly enjoy when going out of the land of Egypt… Manna follows after this. But the third fruit we receive now from the holy land."[1] This is clarified in the footnote, where the editor remarks on Origen's frequent use of three foods as an allegory for the spiritual journey. This allegorical rendering indeed predates Origen, as the Apostle Paul laments in his letter to the Corinthians, "I could not speak to you as spiritual people but rather as fleshly, as infants in Christ. I fed you with milk, not solid food, for you were not ready for solid food."[2]

In his Joshua homilies, Origen reads these foods through the framework of the sustenance of the Israelites entering the world through the Jordan River as baptism. Origen situates the first food out of Egypt as worldly education, which can only sustain the Israelites temporarily as they enter the wilderness of their spiritual journey. In the desert, worldly foods cannot sustain them, and they grumble to Moses until they "enjoy the manna only through…the instructions of the divine law."[3] This can be best understood to mean that through the spiritual journeys of life, worldly education, e.g., secular training, can only sustain the Israelites provisionally as they venture into the unknowns of spiritual life. Upon entering that wilderness, the Israelites must leave behind their worldly knowledge and become wholly dependent upon God and his divine instruction as sustenance. The manna, like God's commandments for the Israelites, requires only that it be found and kept; no manual labor is necessary to obtain it.

With the nourishment of manna as a reflection of God's Holy training, the Israelites eventually makes it "to a good and spacious land, to a land flowing with milk and honey, to the country of the Canaanites…"[4] It is in this land, after passing through the Jordan River, that the

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[1] *Homilies on Joshua, 69.*
[2] *Holy Bible with Apocrypha, NRSVUE, 1 Cor 3:1-2.*
[3] *Homilies on Joshua, 69.*
[4] *Holy Bible with Apocrypha, NRSVUE, Exodus 3:8.*

Israelites will finally find "the fruit of the palm."[5] The Israelites, thus disciplined into God's people, no longer need to sustain themselves solely on manna. The types of food available to them erupt from a single food into a full buffet. This is the land promised to the Israelites: land rich and providing, where God delivers to them foods better than what they left behind in Egypt. This is also where Origen's allegory on food ends rather abruptly, which would benefit from being extended further into a fourth and final food: Jesus as the bread of life. Indeed, Jesus speaks directly to this in the Gospel of John, "…for my flesh is true food, and my blood is true drink. Those who eat my flesh and drink my blood abide in me and I in them."[6] While these Homilies are limited to Joshua and thus the scope of the foods is limited to the story of the Israelites' exodus to the Holy Land, through tracing Origen's Christological hermeneutic, it follows naturally to find those foods, even the bounty of foods in the Holy Land, in anticipation of Christ's body and the Eucharist as the ultimate, true food, which the Israelites would eventually come to know in the fullness of time through the Incarnation. This allegorical extension more fully realizes Origen's Christological reading into the foods required by the People of God.

Preempting the Israelites' entrance into the Holy Land, Origen states explicitly that Jericho is the world, both in *Homily 6 on Joshua* and *Homily 34 on Luke*, claiming, "We frequently find Jericho to be placed in Scripture as a figure of this world"[7] and, more explicitly, "Jerusalem is paradise, and Jericho is the world."[8] Through his appeal to "the elders,"[9] Origen appears to be relying on patristic and apostolic tradition for this inference, while elsewhere

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[5] *Homilies on Joshua, 69.*
[6] Holy Bible with Apocrypha, NRSVUE, John 6:55-56.
[7] Homilies on Joshua, 72.
[8] Homilies on Luke, 138.
[9] Ibid

qualifying it in his Luke homily through emphatic and repetitive reference to the phrase "going down" to Jericho, intuiting that Jericho is to be understood as the place one descends to. This reading is affirmed by Roukema in his essay on the parable of the Good Samaritan: "In ancient Christianity…this parable [Luke 10] was often interpreted allegorically, in the sense that Jerusalem stood for paradise and Jericho for the world into which man had fallen…"[10] Through Origen's Christological hermeneutic, then, Jericho is positioned as the world entered after one's baptism; that is, the crossing of the Jordan.

Accordingly, Jericho is the first city the Israelites encounter and come to conquer after entering the Holy Land. One cannot enter the Holy Land without being pure, as Origen writes in *Homily 4 on Joshua*, "…if you also have entered the mystic font of baptism… then, with the Jordan parted, you will enter the land of promise by the services of the priests. In this land, Jesus receives you…and becomes for you the leader of a new way."[11] Drawing directly from the Gospels, we know Jesus Christ himself was baptized in the Jordan River, further affirming the significance of the waters of the Jordan in their baptismal function. We find in Origen's *Homily 4*, "After the waves of the Jordan, if we shall have been worthy to enter the land of promise, we shall arrive with gladness and exultation, following the priests of the Lord, our Christ and Savior."[12] Origen, in rendering Joshua as Jesus Christ not only in name, is layering in further Christological functions of Joshua leading the Israelites into the Holy Land. But, one may ask: how can Jericho, as the world, function as the Israelites' first steps into the Holy Land? Isn't the world fallen? Origen answers this question through Joshua's encounter with the angel of the Lord, who commands him to remove his sandals for being on Holy Ground. Origen identifies the

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[10] *Roukema, "The Good Samaritan in Ancient Christianity," 57.*
[11] *Homilies on Joshua, 53.*
[12] *Ibid, 58.*

angel of the Lord as the "chief of the army of the power of the Lord"[13] and asks the question: who else could lead the army of God except Christ? We are told it is the Lord himself that, in His own presence, asserts the Holiness of the land on which he stands. Origen cites Colossians in this reverence of Christ, affirming that He is "the head of every ruler and authority."[14] For in Christ's descent into our flesh and into the fallen world, He has brought about our possibility of entering into Holiness, even in the world, through His 'mere' presence. Indeed, as the Apostle Paul tells us in his second letter to the Corinthians, "So if anyone is in Christ, there is a new creation: everything old has passed away; look, new things have come into being!"[15]

We know from Scripture that Christ will indeed return, and Origen renders the conquering of Jericho after the Israelites' initial entrance as that victorious second coming. Several dynamics are found here through the allegorical function of the trumpet. Just as the Israelites, led by Joshua, overcame the fortified walls of Jericho through trumpet blasts, so too will the second coming of Christ be marked by trumpets. Indeed, remarkably, as Origen suggests, it is not through violence: "The sword is not drawn against it; the battering ram is not arranged, nor is the spear hurled. The priestly trumpets alone are employed, and by these the walls of Jericho are overthrown."[16] Origen invokes the Apostle Paul here through a Christological lens: "For the trumpet will sound, and the dead will be raised imperishable, and we will be changed."[17] Beyond this Pauline reading of Origen's Homily, the Psalmist affirms the role and occasion of trumpets and alludes to Christ's return marked by them in Psalm 98, "With trumpets and the sound of the horn make a joyful noise before the King, the Lord… for he is coming to

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[13] *Ibid, 70.*
[14] *Holy Bible with Apocrypha, NRSVUE, Col 2:10.*
[15] *Ibid, 2 Cor 5:17.*
[16] *Homilies on Joshua, 72.*
[17] *Holy Bible with Apocrypha, NRSVUE, 1 Cor 15:52.*

judge the earth."[18] Given Origen's powerful familiarity with scripture, it is curious that in this Homily he did not draw from the Book of Revelation, particularly its repeated refrains of the heralding of trumpets in Chapters 8 and 9 signaling the imminent return of Christ. Indeed, even the number of seven days of marching and trumpet blowing leading to the walls of Jericho falling is mirrored in Revelation by "the seven angels who had the seven trumpets made ready to blow them."[19] Origen nonetheless sustains and concludes this reading of the conquering of Jericho: "At that time, therefore, Jesus our Lord conquers Jericho with trumpets and overthrows it…"[20]

In conclusion, Origen's Homilies on Joshua feature an extensive and almost exclusively Christological hermeneutic and intertextual exegesis. Throughout these Homilies, Origen regularly reads Jesus Christ directly into the story of Joshua, enabling an extended allegorical reading of the crossing of the Jordan into the Holy Land as a broader spiritual journey for Christians. In situating the story of the Israelites' exodus and baptism into the Holy Land, Origen first equipped them and the reader with a spiritual understanding of the foods required for and obtained throughout their journey. While Origen's intertextual readings and allegories are remarkably and broadly profound, there were also opportunities to extend them further, both in the allegory of the spiritual foods and the intertextuality of the trumpets at Jericho.

[18] *Ibid, Ps 98:6, 9.*
[19] *Ibid, Rev 8:6.*
[20] *Homilies on Joshua*, 72.

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